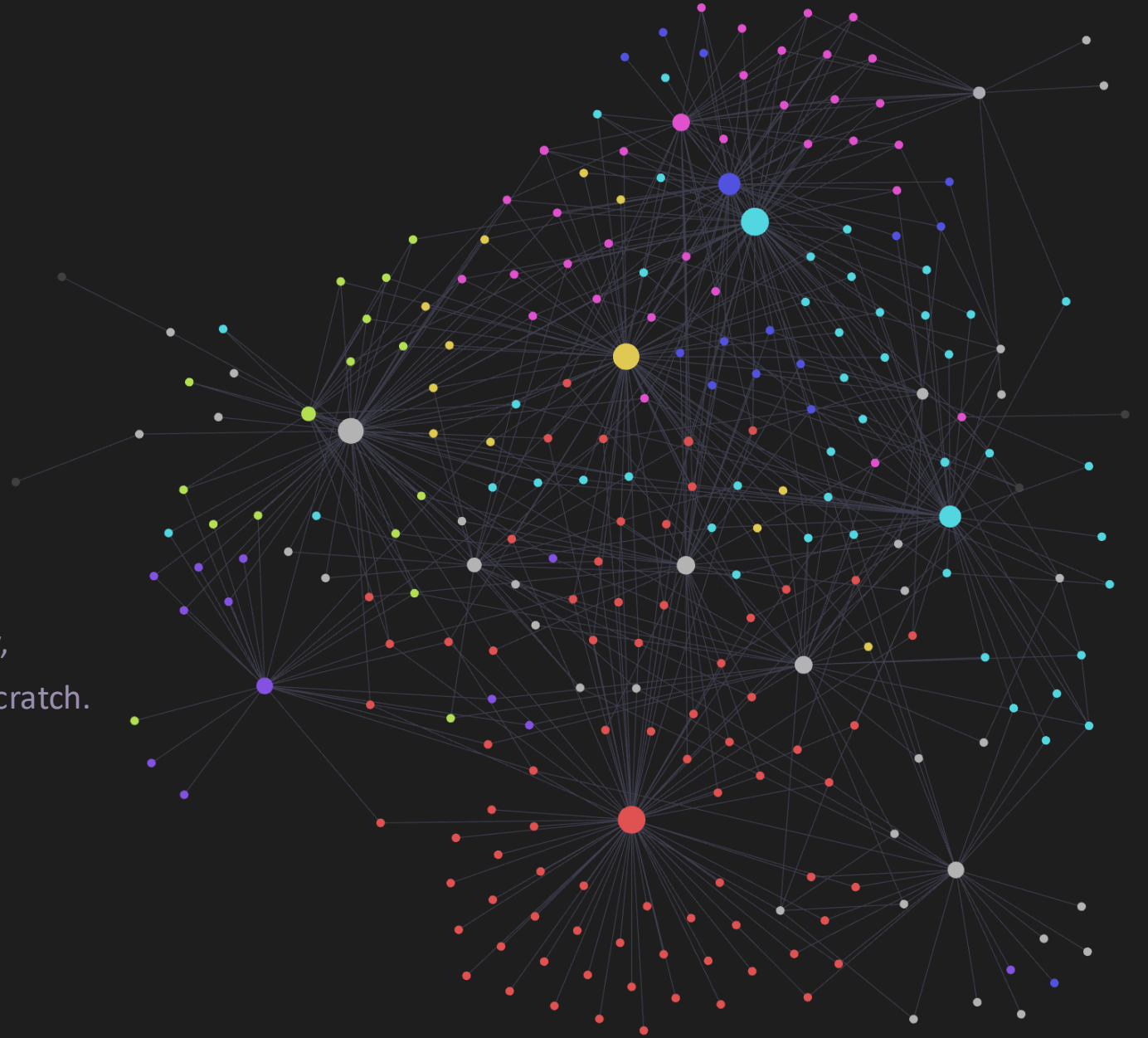


A BEGINNER'S GUIDE

Obsidian

A note-taking tool for research, science, bibliography,
and project & task management — explained from scratch.

PLAIN-TEXT NOTES • LOCAL FILES • LINKED THINKING



What is Obsidian?

Obsidian is a free app for taking notes as plain-text Markdown files, stored locally on your computer. Instead of folders alone, you connect notes to each other with links — turning your notes into a personal, explorable web of ideas.



Markdown files

Notes are plain .md text files you fully own



Your computer

Stored locally in a folder called a "vault"



Free to use

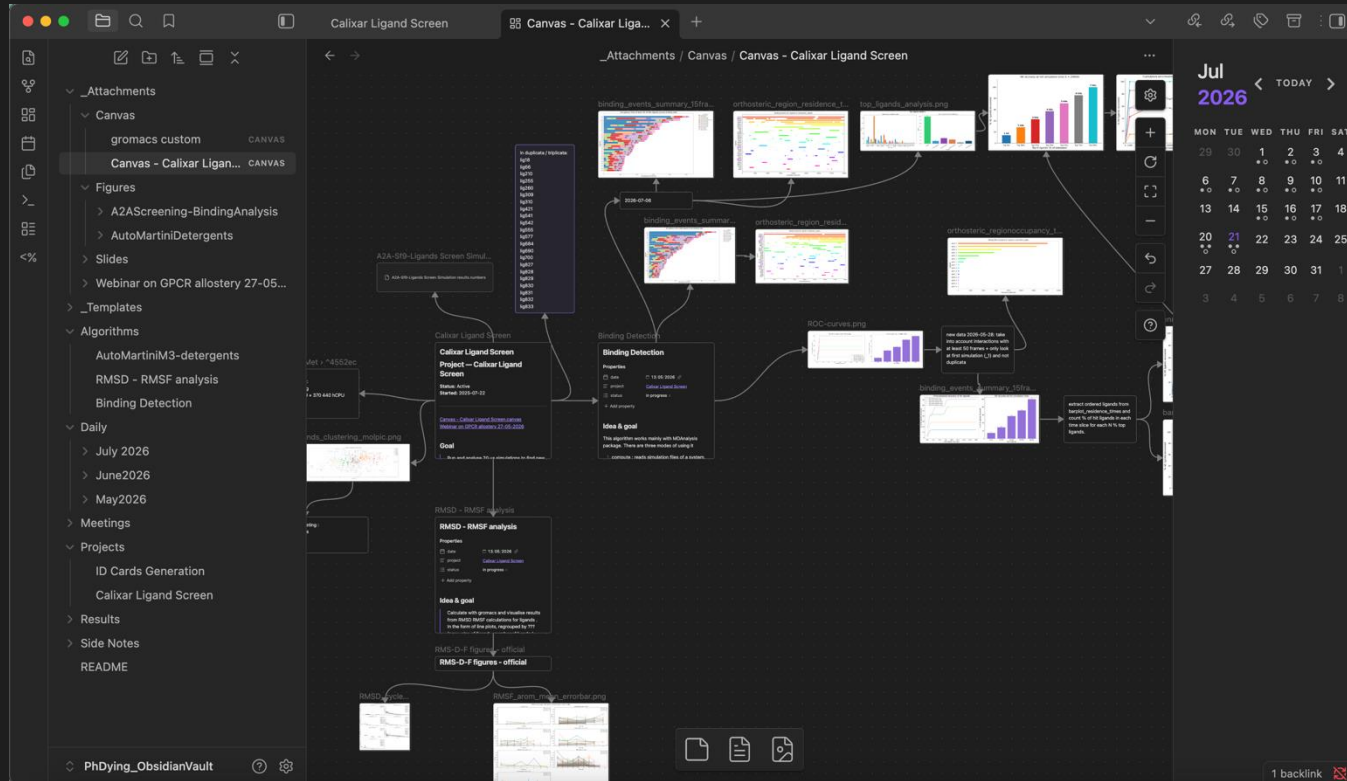
Core app is free; optional paid sync/publish



1000+ plugins

Extend it for almost any workflow

Four ideas explain almost everything



Vault

A folder on your computer holding all your notes. You can have several vaults for different areas of life.



Notes

Each note is a simple Markdown text file — readable in any text editor, forever, even without Obsidian.



Graph view

A visual map of every note and link — patterns and connections you didn't know were there become visible.



Links `[[ ]]`

Type `[[note name]]` to connect two notes. Links can be created before the target note even exists.

Why researchers rely on Obsidian



Connect ideas across papers

Link a note about a method to every paper that used it — the connection stays visible, not buried in a folder.



See backlinks automatically

Every note shows everywhere else it's mentioned, so unexpected connections between sources surface on their own.



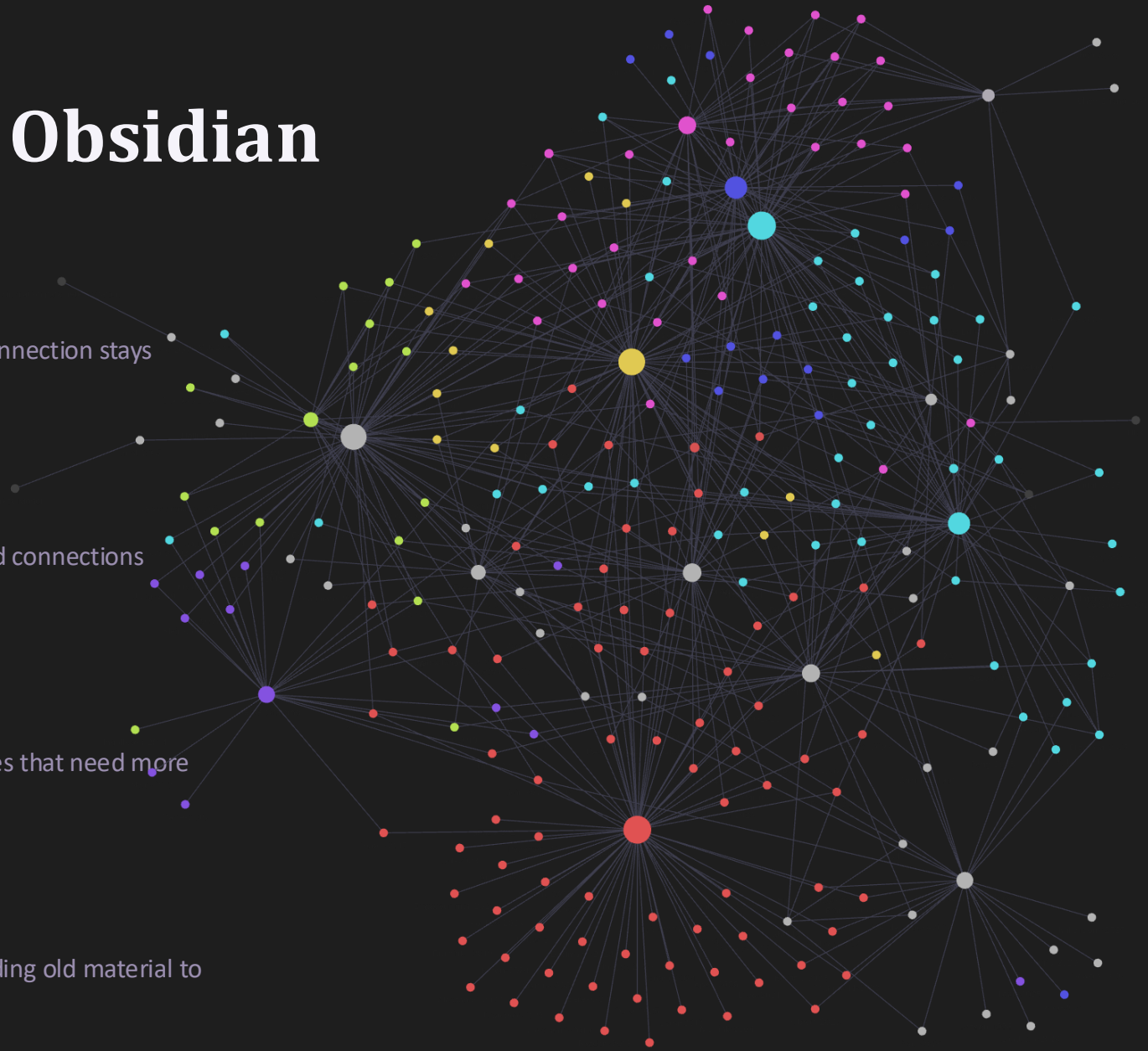
Zoom out with the graph

The graph view reveals clusters of related work and isolated notes that need more connecting.



Full-text search, instantly

Search across thousands of notes and PDFs at once — no re-reading old material to find where an idea came from.



Your research, mapped as it grows

Pros



Free core app

Full note-taking features cost nothing; only sync/publish add-ons are paid.



You own your files

Plain Markdown files — no lock-in, no proprietary format, readable forever.



Works fully offline

No internet connection needed; everything lives on your device.



Deep customization

Community plugins and themes adapt it to almost any workflow.



Fast, local search

Instant full-text search across huge vaults, even with many PDFs attached.



Future-proof

Because notes are plain text, they'll open in any editor, decades from now.

Cons



Learning curve

Linking, plugins, and Markdown syntax take longer to learn than a simple notes app.



No built-in real-time collaboration

Not designed for co-editing a note live with others, unlike Notion or Google Docs.



Mobile app is lighter

Some plugins and heavy vaults behave less smoothly on phones and tablets.



Sync costs extra

Official sync/publish across devices is a paid add-on (free alternatives exist, but need setup).



Organization is on you

Few built-in rules — an unstructured vault can get messy without personal discipline.



Plugin quality varies

Community plugins are powerful but not all are equally polished or maintained.

Obsidian vs. other popular tools

	Obsidian	Notion	Evernote	Roam Research
Storage	Local files	Cloud	Cloud	Cloud
File format	Markdown	Proprietary	Proprietary	Proprietary
Works offline	Yes	Limited	Limited	Limited
Bi-directional links	Yes	Limited	No	Yes
Real-time collab.	No	Yes	Limited	Yes
Price	Free core	Free / paid	Free / paid	Paid

A simplified comparison — each tool has configurations and plugins that shift these trade-offs.

Bibliography & citation management

Obsidian isn't a citation manager itself — it pairs with one. Reference tools like Zotero export your library, and community plugins bring that library straight into your notes.



Pull references from Zotero or a BibTeX file and insert formatted citations directly into a note.



One note per source

Give every paper its own note — link it to concepts, projects, and other papers it relates to.



PDF annotation

Bring highlights and comments from your PDF reader into linked, searchable notes.



Literature maps

The graph view turns a reading list into a visual map of how sources relate to each other.

The screenshot shows the Obsidian application interface. On the left, a sidebar displays a list of notes under the 'Bibliography' folder, including 'Ahmed-2023', 'Ahn-2020', 'Alessandri-2019', 'Alessandri-2022', 'Amārandi-2024', 'Arakawa-2025', 'Aranda-García-2025' (selected), 'Araya-2024', 'Aureli-2025', 'Baaden-2013', 'Badaoui-2018', 'Bartocci-2024', 'Beck-2024', 'Beiter-2024', 'Bereau-2015', 'Bereau-2021', 'Bergazin-2021', 'Beutler-1994', 'Bi-2025', 'Biggin-2025', 'Bigting-2025', 'Blanco-González-2024', 'Beck-2025', 'Borges-Araújo-2022', and 'Borges-Araújo-2023'. The main area displays the content of the 'Aranda-García-2025' note. The note has a title 'Aranda-García-2025' and a 'Properties' section with fields for 'title', 'year', 'link', and 'journal'. The 'title' field contains 'Large scale investigation of GPCR molecular dynamics data uncovers allosteric sites and lateral gateways', 'year' is '2025', 'link' is 'https://www.nature.com/articles/s41467-025-57034-y', and 'journal' is 'Nature Communications'. There is an 'Authors' section listing David Aranda-García, Tomasz Maciej Stepniowski, Mariona Torrens-Fontanals, Adrian García-Recio, Marta Lopez-Balastegui, Brian Medel-Lacruz, Adrián Morales-Pastor, Alejandro Peralta-García, Miguel Dieguez-Eceolaza, David Sotillo-Núñez, Tianyi Ding, Matthäus Drabek, Célien Jacquemard, Jakub Jakowiecki, Willem Jaspers, Mireia Jiménez-Rosés, Víctor Jun-Yu-Lim, Alessandro Nicoli, Urszula Orzel, Aida Shahraki, Johanna K. S. Tiemann, Vicente Ledesma-Martín, Francho Nerín-Fonz, Sergio Suárez-Dou, Oriol Canal, Gáspár Pándy-Szekeres, Jiafei Mao, David E. Gloriam, Esther Kellenberger, Dorota Latek, Ramon Guixà-González, Hugo Gutiérrez-de-Terán, Irina G. Tikhonova, Peter W. Hildebrand, Marta Filizola, M. Madan Babu, Antonella Di Pizio, Sławomir Filipek, Peter Kolb, Arnau Cordomi, Toni Giorgino, Maria Marti-Solano & Jana Selent. There is also a 'Categories' section with the categories 'All-Atom', 'Molecular dynamics', and 'Protein-Ligand Interaction'. The 'Abstract' section contains the text: 'G protein-coupled receptors (GPCRs) constitute a functionally diverse protein family and are targets for a broad spectrum of pharmaceuticals. Technological progress in X-ray crystallography and cryogenic electron microscopy has enabled extensive, high-resolution structural characterisation of GPCRs in different conformational states. However, as highly dynamic events'.

Task & project management



Checkboxes anywhere

Turn any line into a task with "- []"; check it off right inside your notes.



The Tasks plugin

Gathers every checkbox across your whole vault into one dashboard, filterable by due date or tag.



Kanban boards

A plugin adds drag-and-drop boards — great for tracking a project's stages.



Tags & projects

Tag notes and tasks by project (#thesis, #grant-2026) and pull them together with search.

Project: Field Study 2026



Draft literature review



Submit ethics approval



Collect pilot data



Analyze results in R



Write discussion section

Time management with daily notes

A new note opens automatically for today, tomorrow, or any date — a natural home for logging what you did, planning what's next, and linking straight to the projects and papers involved.



Daily notes

One note per day, created automatically from a template — journal, log, or planner.



Periodic notes plugin

Extends the idea to weekly, monthly, and yearly notes for reviews and long-range planning.



A built-in calendar view

See a month at a glance and jump straight into any day's note.



Templates

Pre-fill each day with goals, a task list, and a mood or focus log — created once, reused daily.

Getting started, step by step

1



Install & open

Download Obsidian (free) for your computer or phone and create a new vault — just a folder.



2



Write your first notes

Start plainly: one note per topic, paper, or day. Don't worry about structure yet.



3



Start linking

As ideas repeat, connect them with `[[links]]`. Structure emerges from your notes, not before them.



4



Add a plugin

Once comfortable, add one plugin that solves a real need — Tasks, Calendar, or Citations.

Tip: don't over-plan folders and tags up front — a vault's structure works best when it grows from real use.

IN SHORT

One tool, one vault, endless connections.

Obsidian trades built-in structure for flexibility and ownership: your notes, your files, your connections — useful for research, bibliography, tasks, and time, once you're willing to build the system yourself.

obsidian.md

